This book doesn't aim to be a comprehensive manual on Docker: several other books serve that aim. Rather, this book is your field manual to *building Rails applications with Docker.* We'll cover the most useful commands and features that you'll need, and I'll refer you to reference material as needed.

If you're curious to discover how Docker can fit into your day-to-day workflow as a Rails developer, you've come to the right place.

What's in This Book?

In Part I, you'll learn everything you need to know about using Docker for local Rails development, including core concepts like containers and images. You'll build up real-world knowledge, step by step, through a series of practical tasks. We'll start with the basics—running a Ruby script and generating a new Rails project—before learning how to run our Rails app by building our own custom image.

We'll quickly move on to Compose, a higher-level Docker tool for declaratively describing an entire app, and how it all fits together. As you learn more, we'll gradually layer up services like a database and Redis. We'll cover how to set up and run your tests so that you're fully proficient at using Docker for Rails development.

In Part II, we'll explore the process of deploying and running an application in production. We'll start by giving you an overview of the production landscape—the tools, platforms, and technologies that can be used. Next, using Docker's own tools, we'll provision machines, create a cluster, and deploy our app. We'll also scale our app's resources to meet its changing needs.

How to Read This Book

Docker has a challenging learning curve. It's a vast tool and ecosystem, and there's a lot to understand. Hopefully this book will help—it's carefully structured to avoid introducing too many new things at once.

Each chapter builds on the one preceding it, so, especially if you're unfamiliar with Docker, I recommend reading the book in sequence to get the most benefit. Even if you have more Docker experience under your belt already, this is the recommended approach.